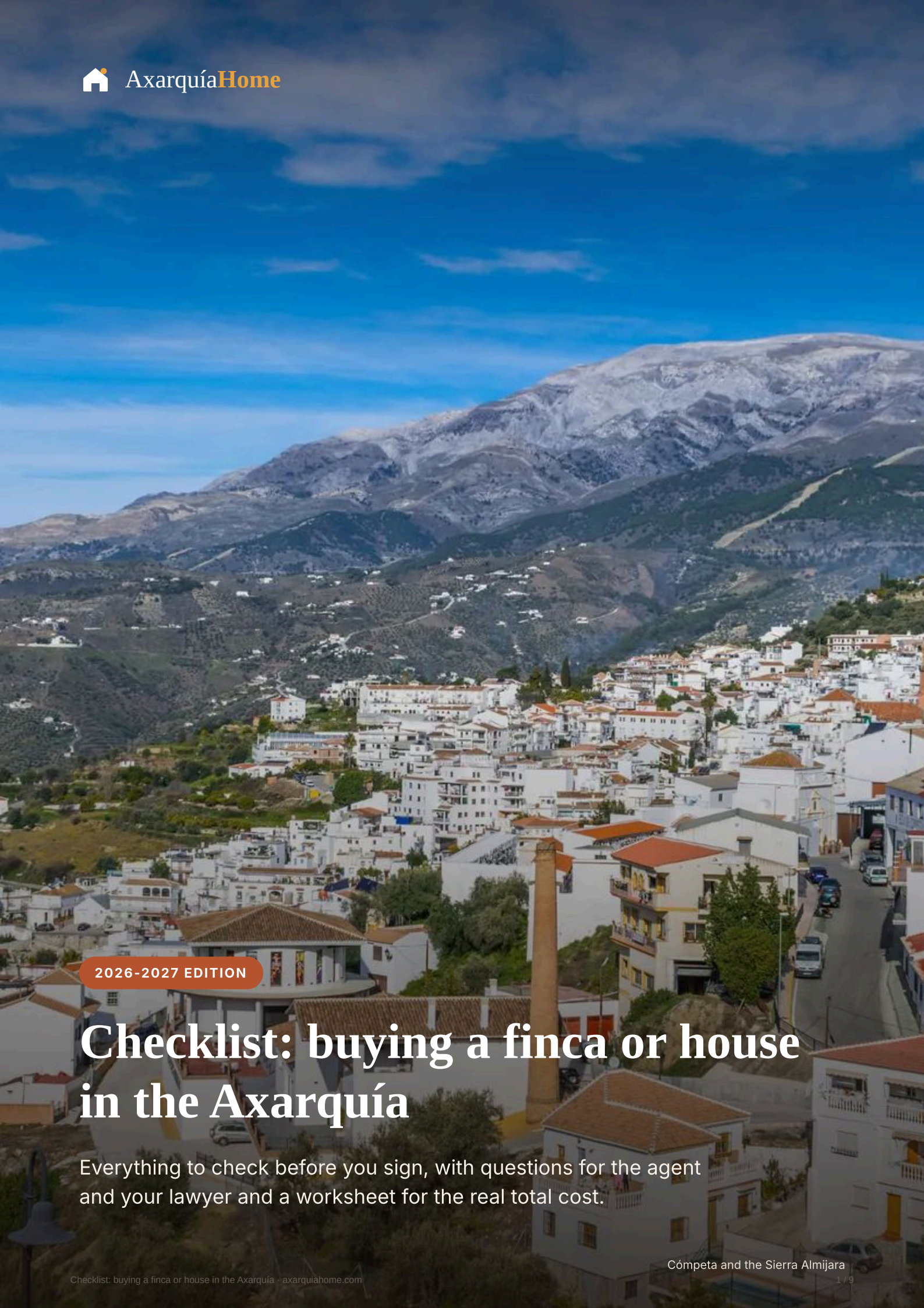
AxarquíaHome



2026-2027 EDITION

Checklist: buying a finca or house in the Axarquía

Everything to check before you sign, with questions for the agent and your lawyer and a worksheet for the real total cost.

Cómpeta and the Sierra Almijara

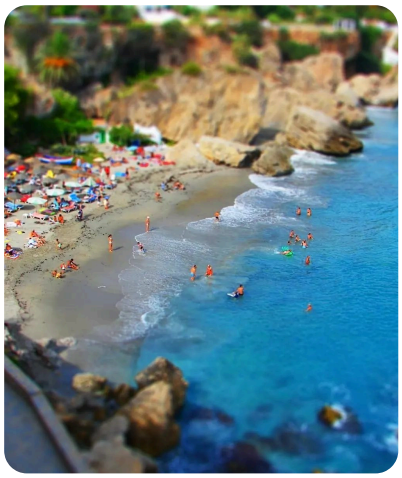
Welcome to the Axarquía

White villages against the mountains, terraces full of olive, almond and avocado trees, and a coastline of little coves beneath the cliffs. The Axarquía, east of Málaga, is one of the most beautiful places in Andalusia to live.

With around 300 days of sunshine a year, Málaga airport about an hour's drive away and villages such as Frigiliana, Cómpeta and Nerja, it is easy to see why more and more Dutch, German, Swedish and British buyers settle here. This checklist helps you do it with peace of mind.



Frigiliana



A cove below the cliffs of Nerja



Canillas de Albaida

For most people, buying a home in the Axarquía is a dream come true. Yet every year we meet buyers who get a nasty surprise after the keys are handed over: an extension without a permit, a well that runs dry in summer, a roof that leaks at the first rain, or a renovation that costs twice what they expected.

Almost all of those surprises can be spotted in advance if you know what to look for. This checklist puts everything in order, in the sequence you will come across it: from the first viewing to the first weeks after the purchase. Tick off what you have checked and take the list with you to viewings.



The coast at Nerja

1. Before you start viewing

The asking price is not what the house costs. Work out the total before you fall in love.

- [ ] Total budget set: purchase price + about 10% buying costs + a renovation reserve
- [ ] For an older finca, 15 to 30% of the purchase price set aside for renovation
- [ ] Own funds arranged: Spanish banks usually lend non-residents at most 60 to 70% of the value
- [ ] NIE number (tax number for foreigners) applied for, you need it at the notary
- [ ] Spanish bank account opened or in progress
- [ ] Independent lawyer chosen, not the agent's or the seller's
- [ ] Clear on how you will use the house: live there, spend the winter, or rent it out (holiday letting needs a tourist licence)



The village square of Canillas de Albaida

2. During the viewing

Look beyond the view. Bring a torch and take plenty of photos.

- [ ] Cracks in walls, especially diagonal cracks above windows and doors or at extensions
- [ ] Damp patches, mould or flaking paint at the bottom of walls and in corners
- [ ] Ceilings and roof beams: sagging, woodworm (small holes and sawdust), traces of leaks
- [ ] Flat roofs and terraces: cracks in the finish, standing water, blocked drains
- [ ] Electrics: old sockets without earth, loose cables, an outdated fuse box
- [ ] Windows and doors: single glazing, rotten wood, do they close properly?
- [ ] Bathroom and kitchen: leaks under the sink, water pressure, hot water
- [ ] Pool: cracks, water loss, condition of pump and filter
- [ ] Position on the slope: retaining walls, subsidence, drainage in heavy rain
- [ ] Sun and wind: where does the sun fall in winter, and where does the wind come from?
- [ ] Access by car and for a lorry or concrete mixer
- [ ] Mobile signal and internet tested on site

Do you recognise this?

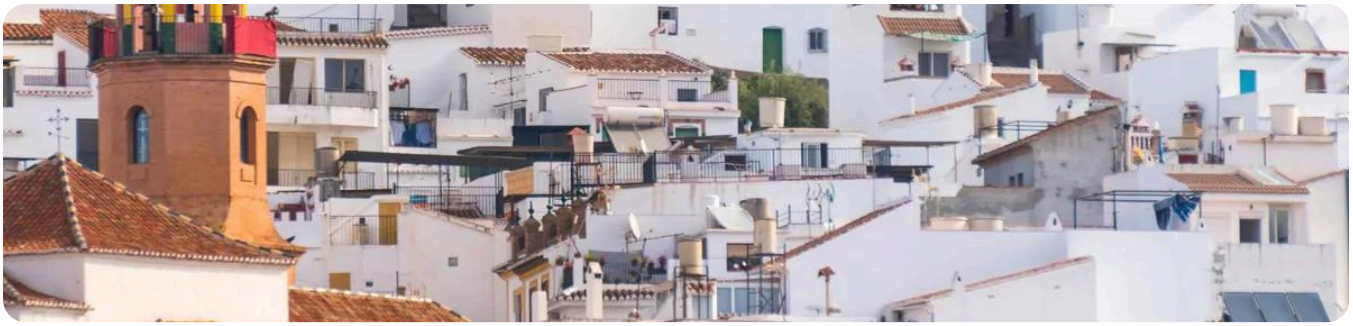
Damp and leaks are the most common hidden defects in homes in the Axarquía. A fresh coat of paint often hides them during a viewing.



Rising damp: flaking paint at the bottom of a wall



A leak: a damp stain in the corner of the ceiling



Cómpeta

3. Legal status and paperwork

This is the most important part. Your lawyer checks it, but you should know what needs checking.

- [ ] Nota simple requested from the Land Registry (Registro de la Propiedad): owner, mortgages, charges
- [ ] Cadastre (Catastro) compared with the registry and with what is actually there: does the floor area match?
- [ ] Permits seen for the house and for extensions, pool, garage and outbuildings
- [ ] For a house on rural land: is there an AFO certificate (asimilado a fuera de ordenación)?
- [ ] Checked with the town hall whether any proceedings or fines are pending
- [ ] Habitability: licencia de primera ocupación or certificado de ocupación
- [ ] Energy certificate (certificado energético) received, it is mandatory for a sale
- [ ] IBI (property tax) and refuse tax paid for recent years
- [ ] For an apartment or urbanisation: no arrears with the community of owners, and minutes read
- [ ] Renting out? Check whether a tourist licence (VFT) is possible or already in place
- [ ] The house is not in a protected natural area, a flood zone or too close to a riverbed



The valley below Canillas de Albaida

4. Water, drainage, power and internet

In the countryside you arrange this yourself. A finca without a reliable water supply soon loses its charm.

- [ ] Water source clear: mains, irrigation water (comunidad de regantes), own well or tank
- [ ] For a well or spring: registration or concession seen, and water quality tested
- [ ] Asked how much water was available in recent dry summers
- [ ] Drainage: connected to the sewer, or a septic tank? If so: where is it, and is it watertight?
- [ ] Electricity: connected to the grid, and with what capacity (potencia contratada)?
- [ ] With solar panels: capacity of panels and batteries, and is there a generator?
- [ ] Enough capacity for air conditioning, pool pump, heat pump or an electric car?
- [ ] Internet: fibre, 4G/5G or satellite, and what does it cost?



Frigiliana on the mountainside

5. Access, land and neighbours

- [ ] Does the access road run over public land or over the neighbours' land?
- [ ] If not: right of way (servidumbre de paso) recorded in the registry
- [ ] Who maintains the road, and is it passable after heavy rain?
- [ ] Plot boundaries clear and matching the cadastre
- [ ] Trees and terraces: who prunes the olive, almond or avocado trees, and what does it cost?
- [ ] Fire prevention: keeping vegetation clear around the house is compulsory in wooded areas
- [ ] Had a chat with the neighbours: about water, the road, noise and plans nearby



Steps in the old quarter of Frigiliana

6. Questions to ask

The agent or seller

1. Why is the house for sale, and how long has it been on the market?
2. Is everything I see licensed, including the pool and extensions?
3. How old are the roof, electrics, pipes and septic tank?
4. What major repairs have been done in the last ten years, and are there invoices?
5. Where does the water come from, and was there enough in recent summers?
6. What are the yearly running costs: IBI, refuse, water, power, insurance, community fees?
7. Are there any disputes with neighbours or the town hall?
8. Is the house rented out, and does it have a tourist licence?
9. Which furniture and contents stay?
10. Is there room on the price if the survey shows defects?

Your lawyer

1. Does the nota simple match the cadastre and reality?
2. Is the house fully legal, does it have AFO status, or neither? What does that mean for me?
3. Will I be allowed to renovate, extend or build a pool later?
4. Are there debts, charges or mortgages that must be cleared before completion?
5. Is the seller non-resident? Then I must withhold 3%: will you handle that?
6. What does the arras contract say, and when would I lose my deposit?
7. Who pays the plusvalía tax? (By law, the seller)
8. Is the water supply legally attached to the property?
9. What are my yearly taxes as a non-resident (IRNR)?
10. Exactly which buying costs apply, and when do I pay them?

7. Worksheet: what does the house really cost?

Fill in the amounts for the house you are considering. The percentages apply to a resale property in Andalusia.

Purchase price		€
Transfer tax ITP (7%)		€
Notary and Land Registry	€1,000 – €2,500	€
Independent lawyer	about 1% + IVA	€
Gestoría and other	€300 – €700	€
Pre-purchase survey	€400 – €1,000	€
Mortgage costs and valuation (if applicable)		€
Renovation and overdue maintenance	from the survey	€
Furnishing and moving		€
Contingency (10%)		€
Total		**€**

Yearly running costs to budget for: IBI, refuse tax, non-resident tax (IRNR), insurance, water, power, internet, and maintenance or key holding while you are away.

8. The first 30 days after you get the keys

- [ ] Water, electricity and internet transferred to your name
- [ ] Buildings and contents insurance taken out
- [ ] IBI and refuse tax set up by direct debit
- [ ] Locks changed
- [ ] A builder has looked at what needs doing first (roof, electrics, damp) before the next rainy season
- [ ] Arranged who checks the house while you are away: airing, post, inspection after storms
- [ ] Registered with the town hall (padrón) if you are going to live there



Got a house in mind?

Have it surveyed before you sign. Our building surveyor partner checks the structure, roof, damp, electrics, water and drainage, and prices the repair of every defect, so you can negotiate on the price. We can also help with the renovation and looking after the house afterwards.

Request a property survey

axarquiahome.com/en/request/ · info@axarquiahome.com

This checklist gives general information and is not legal or tax advice. The verdict on a specific property comes from a lawyer, architect or aparejador. Amounts are indicative (2026).